

After Action Review Report

The Response to Political Transition in Bangladesh

August 2024-October 2025



July 2026

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

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LIST OF ACRONYMS

AAR:	After Action Review
AL:	Awami League
BCP:	Business Continuity Planning
BERA:	Bureau for External Relations and Advocacy
BMS:	Bureau for Management Services
BNP:	Bangladesh Nationalist Party
BPPS:	Bureau for Policy and Programme Support
BRH:	Bangkok Regional Hub
CB:	Crisis Bureau
CMST:	Crisis Management Support Team
CO:	Country Office
DFAT:	Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade (Australia)
DPPA:	Department of Political and Peacebuilding Affairs
DRR:	Deputy Resident Representative
EU:	European Union
FCDO:	Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office (United Kingdom)
GESI:	Gender Equality and Social Inclusion
GRP:	Global Recovery Platform
HQ:	Headquarters
HR:	Human Resources
IMF:	International Monetary Fund
NCP:	National Citizen Party
PM:	Prime Minister
RBAP:	Regional Bureau for Asia and the Pacific
RC:	Resident Coordinator
RFQ:	Request for Quotation
RR:	Resident Representative
SES:	Social and Environmental Standards

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Background

Bangladesh experienced a major political transition in 2024 following widespread student-led protests initially triggered by the reinstatement of a controversial public sector job quota system. The demonstrations evolved into a nationwide movement, reflecting a range of public concerns related to governance, economic conditions and civic space. On 5th August 2024, Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina fled the country, leading to a period of political uncertainty and subsequent formation of an interim administration headed by Nobel laureate Muhammad Yunus. This transition marked a pivotal moment in Bangladesh's political landscape, opening space for reforms while also creating a complex and fluid operating environment.

In response to the evolving situation, UNDP activated its corporate crisis response mechanisms, and the Crisis Board classified the situation as a Level 3 crisis in August 2024. The Corporate response spanned between August 2024 – October 2025 and provided technical support through immediate SURGE deployments and funding support from TRAC3 and Funding Window.

Following the response and as per the Crisis Response and Recovery SOPs, UNDP is undertaking an After Action Review (AAR), which aims to provide a structured reflection on the crisis response to identify strengths and weaknesses; lessons learned and good practices; to sustain and multiply what was done well, and to identify and address areas for improvement. The present AAR, designed as a light exercise, covers the period of activation of the corporate response to the Bangladesh crisis, with a focus on coordination and clarity in decision-making, the effectiveness of programme interventions and corporate support mechanisms, and the performance of operational functions during the crisis.

Analysis of the Response

Overall, the Review finds that UNDP demonstrated strong institutional capacity and adaptability in responding to the political transition. Coordination between Regional Bureau of Asia and the Pacific (RBAP), the Crisis Bureau (CB), and the Bangladesh CO was effective, with the Bangkok Regional Hub (BRH) serving as the main coordination channel and first responder. Early engagement from regional and headquarters teams helped maintain situational awareness and supported the CO during a rapidly evolving and uncertain period.

Strong leadership from the CO, under the direction of the Resident Representative, played a central role in shaping the response. The CO acted decisively to position UNDP in priority reform areas such as governance, elections, justice sector reform, and civic engagement. Rapid deployment of multidisciplinary SURGE advisors provided specialized expertise and enabled UNDP to engage early with the interim government and reform commissions.

Flexible coordination arrangements between the CO and the BRH, supported by frequent communication and streamlined decision-making channels, facilitated timely responses and alignment around emerging priorities. Access to flexible crisis funding also proved catalytic, allowing UNDP to initiate early support for electoral processes and governance reforms. These early investments strengthened credibility with national counterparts and helped mobilize significant donor resources for governance and electoral support.

Summary of Key Observations and Lessons Learned

The response highlighted several strengths that contributed to UNDP's effectiveness during the political transition. Early strategic positioning, strong CO leadership, the rapid deployment of regionally knowledgeable SURGE advisors, and flexible coordination arrangements enabled timely and meaningful engagement during

a critical moment. The role of the BRH as a first responder was particularly important in providing contextually informed support and sustaining effective coordination between headquarters and the CO.

At the same time, the crisis response revealed areas requiring further strengthening. Preparedness for political crises was limited, particularly with regard to political risk monitoring, scenario planning, and contingency measures for disruptions such as internet shutdowns. Operational challenges emerged in alternative reliable communications, especially during internet blackouts, strengthening Business Continuity Planning, and applying and monitoring of corporate Special Measures. These lessons underscore the need for stronger preparedness frameworks and tools tailored specifically to political transition contexts.

Recommendations

The Review identifies several recommendations to strengthen UNDP's preparedness and response to political transitions.

At the CO level,

priorities include strengthening crisis preparedness through political risk monitoring and scenario planning, improving business continuity and maintaining communication systems such as SAT phones and radios and strengthening HR readiness through pre-identified staffing pipelines.

At the Regional level,

RBAP should continue strengthening the capacity of the Bangkok Regional Hub as a first responder by expanding regional technical surge capacity and maintaining a roster of regionally based governance and political economy advisors. Strengthening regional knowledge- sharing and facilitating peer exchanges between COs would further support learning from comparable political transition contexts.

For the Crisis Bureau,

Priorities include adapting crisis response tools and guidance to better address political transitions; consolidating practical resources within the GRP Hub platform; providing orientation on Special Measures and conflict-sensitive programming; facilitating inter-regional peer learning exchanges; and, in coordination with RBAP, supporting Country Offices in risk monitoring, scenario planning, and political economy analysis to enable more timely and informed responses. Additionally, focus on promoting flexible, demand-driven coordination mechanisms to support faster decision-making in rapidly evolving crises.

1. INTRODUCTION

This AAR assesses UNDP's response to the 2024–2025 political transition in Bangladesh, classified as a Level 3 (L3) crisis, covering the period from August 2024 to August 2025. This was conducted as a light internal learning exercise under UNDP's Crisis Response SOPs. The review examines the clarity and timeliness of decision-making, the effectiveness of programme and operational mechanisms, and the use of corporate support and tools. It briefly reflects on UNDP's response to major floods that occurred shortly after the L3 activation, highlighting the challenges of managing overlapping crises in a politically volatile environment.

1.1 Background and crisis context

Bangladesh entered a period of significant political transition in 2024 as long-standing political tensions, evolving governance dynamics, economic pressures, and a youth-led protest movement converged into a nationwide crisis. The developments marked an important turning point, reshaping political dynamics, highlighting institutional challenges, and ushering in a phase of uncertainty alongside potential opportunities for reform. For 15 years, governance in Bangladesh had been characterized by a highly centralised model that contributed to infrastructure development and macroeconomic gains, while also giving rise to ongoing public debate regarding political participation, opposition engagements and civic and media space. Electoral processes in recent years – including the 2014 and 2024 elections – were subject to varying interpretations among stakeholders, contributing to differing perceptions regarding inclusiveness and political representation. These dynamics, combined with broader socioeconomic pressures, contributed to an environment in which public discontent could more readily mobilize.

The immediate trigger for the crisis was the Supreme Court's reinstatement of a public sector job quota system in mid-2024, which generated significant concern among student groups and was widely perceived as inconsistent with merit-based access to public employment. Student protests intensified in June–July, with reports indicating the use of force and resulting casualties during demonstrations. What began as a sector-specific grievance gradually evolved into nationwide mobilization, with protests and related actions – including strikes and large-scale demonstrations – reflecting a wider set of societal concerns.

By July and August, protest movements had expanded to include broader issues such as addressing corruption, economic mismanagement, unemployment, inflation, and the civic freedoms. As demonstrations intensified in Dhaka in early August, conditions remained fluid and responses varied across contexts. On 5 August, Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina departed the country, leading to a period of institutional uncertainty. The constitution contained provisions for elections within 90 days after a parliamentary dissolution but no clear mechanism for an interim executive authority, resulting in an institutional vacuum that was filled only partially by the subsequent formation of an interim government. The speed and depth of the AL's collapse, party leaders going into hiding, offices attacked, and patronage networks disrupted, highlighted the extent to which its power had rested on centralised control rather than resilient, locally embedded legitimacy. The fall of Sheikh Hasina and the abrupt collapse of the AL's dominance reflected not only the scale of mobilisation but also the regime's narrowing coalition and eroding security-sector support.

This gap produced an immediate governance limbo, with competing expectations from protesters, political parties, and state institutions over who should govern and under what mandate. In the days that followed, a combination of presidential authority, behind-the-scenes negotiations, and the de facto balance of power on the streets shaped the transition arrangements. The President dissolved the 12th Jatiya Sangsad and moved to appoint an interim administration acceptable to the student-led movement and broader opposition forces as a way to defuse tensions and restore basic order. Under intense social pressure and amid a weakened AL and cautious security establishment, Nobel laureate Muhammad Yunus, who had long been a critic of the previous government, emerged as the consensus figure to head the interim government.

On 8 August 2024, Yunus was sworn in as Chief Adviser, leading an extra-constitutional interim cabinet composed largely of figures drawn from civil society, academia, the legal profession, and technocratic backgrounds rather than established party elites. The Supreme Court subsequently affirmed the legality of this “stopgap” arrangement under the doctrine of necessity, recognising the need to fill the constitutional void and prevent state paralysis. The interim government’s mandate was framed around three core tasks: stabilizing the country and curbing violence; launching a set of priority on governance, justice, and security sector reforms; and preparing the ground for free and fair elections and a broader constitutional overhaul.

To operationalize this reform agenda, the interim administration established multiple commissions (Constitutional Reform, Electoral System Reform, Police Reform, Judiciary Reform, Public Administration, Anti-Corruption Reform) and committees, tasked with proposing changes to address structural weaknesses exposed by the crisis—such as the absence of credible safeguards for political transitions, the concentration of executive power, and politicization of key institutions. It also committed to a constituent-assembly-type process and a constitutional referendum, eventually linking these to the elections held in February 2026. Parallel steps included the release of political prisoners, the lifting or relaxation of restrictions on parties such as Jamaat-e-Islami, and initial moves toward security sector and electoral reform, all intended to signal a break with the previous era and widen political space.

The unprecedented fall of the government exposed major constitutional weaknesses, particularly the absence of mechanisms to manage political transitions during emergencies. This prompted renewed debate on the need for legal safeguards, stronger rule-of-law frameworks, and improved accountability mechanisms. The interim government’s commitment to constitutional reform marked the beginning of a longer-term effort to redesign Bangladesh’s governance architecture.

This political inflection point coincided with a succession of climate-induced disasters that exposed the structural vulnerability of Bangladesh’s governance systems. From June 2024, severe monsoon floods and landslides affected millions, overwhelming local capacities and disrupting critical infrastructure and services in multiple districts. Subsequent flooding in the eastern and southeastern regions, including devastating events around August, further compounded humanitarian needs and put additional pressure on national coordination mechanisms amid political change. The interim authorities were thus required to simultaneously consolidate their legitimacy, manage heightened expectations, and orchestrate a complex, multi-actor disaster response.

Political tensions preceding the elections influenced the responsiveness and coherence of institutional actors, while post-election dynamics shaped the extent to which coordinated recovery and resilience-building efforts could be undertaken. Flood responses, occurring within this politically charged atmosphere, demanded simultaneous attention to immediate humanitarian imperatives and longer-term governance considerations, including equitable service delivery and conflict sensitivity.

Against this backdrop, Bangladesh’s 2024 political transition stands as a watershed moment characterised by mass mobilization, institutional breakdown, and a reopening of political space. While the upheaval revealed profound structural governance challenges, it also generated momentum for democratic renewal. With national elections held in February 2026, the durability of emerging reforms and the capacity of new and reconfigured political actors to respond credibly to public expectations will be critical in shaping Bangladesh’s future trajectory and its ability to withstand and manage future crises.

1.2 Objective and scope of After-Action Review (AAR)

Guided by the Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) on Crisis Response, UNDP conducts AAR following crisis response activations to capture lessons learned and strengthen future responses. The objective of this AAR is to critically examine UNDP's crisis response in order to enhance institutional readiness, improve decision-making and coordination, and increase programme and operational agility in future emergencies. The scope of the AAR focuses on three core areas: *(i) the clarity and timeliness of decision-making and coordination during the crisis; (ii) the effectiveness of programme interventions and the use of corporate mechanisms; and (iii) the performance of operational functions, including procurement, logistics, staffing, and security.*

The Review also identifies lessons to inform crisis preparedness and response, particularly in contexts of political transition. Through this reflective process, the AAR documents strengths, gaps, and good practices, and identifies areas for improvement to support continuous organizational learning, with focused analysis on UNDP's corporate response to the political transition in Bangladesh.

2. METHODOLOGY

The AAR was conducted as an internal UNDP exercise, designed as a light, lessons learned process to support institutional learning and strengthen future crisis preparedness and response. The methodology combined primary and secondary data collection methods with structured analytical dimensions to assess UNDP's programme and operational engagement during the crisis.

Overall Approach

The AAR followed a streamlined, internally-led approach aimed at capturing key insights into what worked well, areas requiring improvement, and good practices. The Review process consisted of three main components:

1. **Desk Review of Key Documents**

A comprehensive review of relevant UNDP internal documentation was undertaken, with emphasis on materials produced during the corporate response period. These included documents related to corporately institutionalized processes such as Crisis Board and Crisis Management Support Team (CMST) meetings, strategic and operational guidance, situation analyses, programmatic updates, and internal communications.

2. **Key Informant Interviews (KIIs)**

Semi-structured interviews were conducted with the selected staff from the CO, RBAP, CB and SURGE Advisors to gather diverse perspectives. The interviews focused on capturing reflections on the effectiveness of the response, bottlenecks, and opportunities for strengthening corporate systems.

3. **Synthesis and Reporting**

Findings from the desk review and interviews were synthesized into a concise report highlighting key lessons and practical recommendations aimed at enhancing institutional preparedness and response mechanisms.

3. ANALYSIS OF UNDP RESPONSE

3.1 UNDP Bangladesh structure and response capacity

UNDP Bangladesh has a substantial programme and operational capacity, built over 52 years of supporting national development through extensive poverty reduction, governance, and climate portfolios, and delivering USD 40–60 million annually through a workforce of approximately 380 personnel, including 47 Fixed-Term staff of which 7 are international staff. This capacity had been calibrated to the needs of a rapidly growing and modernizing country; however, the political crisis in 2024 demanded additional SURGE capacity to anticipate and respond to the interim Government's requests, particularly in Police Reform, Electoral Assistance, Justice

Sector Reform, Civic Engagement (with a focus on youth and civil society), partnership- building, and resource mobilization.

3.2 Clarity and Timeliness of Decision Making for the Response

Overall, the crisis response was characterised by timely decision-making, strong vertical and horizontal communication, prompt activation of corporate mechanisms, and pragmatic coordination approaches. While the complexity and sensitivity of the political context required careful navigation, these factors did not hinder the responsiveness or effectiveness of UNDP's engagement.

Clear Roles and Leadership at Crisis Onset

Roles and responsibilities were clearly defined at the onset of the Crisis Response. Senior management from RBAP and the CB demonstrated a shared and coherent understanding of UNDP's mandate and strategic positioning in a politically sensitive environment. This clarity at the corporate and regional levels translated into purposeful and confident action at the CO.

The Resident Representative (RR) and Deputy Resident Representative (DRR) provided strong and consistent leadership, effectively guiding the overall direction of the response. Their proactive engagement ensured that UNDP's value proposition was clearly articulated within the UN system and strategically positioned with the Government during a rapidly evolving political transition. This early clarity in leadership and mandate helped minimize ambiguity at a critical time, enabling swift, coordinated, and well-aligned action when it was most needed.

Early Engagement and Support

Crisis Response Support began early, even before formal declarations were made. From mid-July, RBAP and UNDSS in Bangkok and New York were already closely engaged with the CO, maintaining consistent communication despite significant connectivity constraints and an unpredictable operating environment. This early engagement ensured situational awareness and enabled immediate actions ahead of the formal crisis classification. The CO prioritized the safety and security of personnel through regular headcounts, the postponement of field activities, and daily meetings of the Security Management Team. Measures were also implemented to ensure continuity, including maintaining emergency cash reserves, safeguarding office assets, and supporting staff wellbeing.

The proactive involvement from RBAP and UNDSS reassured the CO and facilitated a smoother transition into formal response modalities once the situation escalated. Importantly, this early support helped reduce uncertainty and ensured that the CO was not operating in isolation during the initial phase of unrest.

Streamlined Communication

The BRH (RBAP and CB) played a critical bridging and coordination role during the acute phase of the crisis, linking real-time developments on the ground with corporate decision-making processes. By streamlining communication flows and consolidating requests from headquarters, this prevented operational overload at the CO. This intermediary function was particularly important in a high-pressure environment where the CO needed to prioritize engagement with national counterparts and manage immediate programmatic demands.

Weekly coordination calls between BRH (RBAP and CB) and the CO (RR and DRR) during the initial weeks were particularly effective. These calls provided a structured platform to align decisions related to SURGE deployments, financial allocations, and strategic positioning. During the most intense phase of the situation, communication was more frequent, initially including daily check-ins. This frequent and regular interaction ensured that decision-making remained responsive to rapidly evolving developments on the ground. This level of engagement was already in place before formal mechanisms such as the activation of Crisis Board and the Country Management Support Team (CMST).

Crisis Board and CMST Activation

As the situation escalated, formal corporate mechanisms were activated in a timely and structured manner. UNDP classified the situation as a Level 3 crisis, following a Crisis Board meeting convened on 13th August 2024. The Crisis Board authorized USD 2 million for the immediate response and approved the deployment of SURGE capacity to support the CO in responding to the Interim Government's priorities. Priority areas of support included governance, civic engagement, anti-corruption, and police reform, areas aligned with both national needs and UNDP's comparative advantage.

Subsequently, CMST meetings were convened to operationalize and monitor the implementation of Crisis Board Decisions. These meetings provided a structured forum to review progress, address operational issues, and maintain alignment between corporate guidance and country-level realities, helping ensure systematic follow-up and accountability.

Convening CMST meetings proved challenging, because of time differences between New York, Dhaka and Bangkok and the availability of senior managers. In practice, more regular catch-ups—weekly and sometimes daily communications—between BRH (CB and RBAP) and CO senior management were more effective for sharing updates and making timely decisions based on evolving priorities.

- **UNDP convened the first Crisis Board meeting on 13 August 2024, resulting in the classification of the situation as a Level 3 crisis.**
- **The first Crisis Management Support Team (CMST) meeting was convened on 9 September 2024, during which a decision was made to allocate USD 1 million from TRAC 3 for the immediate flood response.**
- **The second CMST meeting was convened on 11 March 2025, which resulted in the de-escalation from Level 3 to Level 1.**
- **The final CMST meeting was convened on 15 October 2025, leading to the de-escalation of the response and closure of Level 1.**

Coordination within the UN System

UNDP's coordination with the broader UN system and external partners benefited from strong senior-level engagement. The RR, supported by SURGE advisors, worked closely with the UNCT to ensure that UNDP could clearly define and communicate its programme offer within the UN's collective engagement framework. CO leadership expressed appreciation for the "light-touch," well-coordinated support received from regional and headquarters levels while working with the UNCT. More effective collaboration emerged organically around priority reform areas. For example, in Electoral Assistance, UNDP took a leadership role and worked constructively with DPPA and other UN actors. This thematic, issue-based coordination proved more efficient and impactful than broader and less focused engagements.

At the same time, some local coordination challenges were observed, prompted by periods of RC's absence and instances of agencies competing for visibility during the politically charged transition. These dynamics highlighted the need for unified yet pragmatic engagement that balances collective positioning with clarity of comparative advantage.

3.3 Programmatic Response and use of Corporate Support

Programmatic Response

UNDP's programme response was timely and aligned with needs emerging from the political transition. The approach balanced the importance of maintaining institutional continuity with UNDP's active and visible contribution to reform efforts in a rapidly changing environment. UNDP moved quickly to scale up and redirect existing resources, prioritizing support for youth and civic engagement, governance and institutional reforms and peacebuilding initiatives.

UNDP engaged early and decisively in governance, justice, police reform, and civic engagement, including collaboration with newly established commissions. The political transition created a narrow but important window of opportunity to advance reforms related to democratic governance, human rights, judicial independence, and electoral processes. The CO senior management identified this opportunity early and positioned UNDP accordingly.

These efforts contributed to tangible results, including strengthened judicial independence, the adoption of a new National Human Rights Commission ordinance, support for electoral preparations, and initial reforms of economic and commercial codes. UNDP's proactive approach helped establish credibility and a clear role, even when other partners remained cautious.

UNDP also worked closely with the UN Country Team (UNCT) on reform initiatives, maintaining coordination with agencies such as UN Women, UNODC, UNESCO, OHCHR, and UNFPA. Joint efforts supported electoral processes, advanced human rights initiatives, and facilitated the development of peacebuilding proposals, while work on politically-sensitive areas such as Security Sector Reform progressed more cautiously. Within the UNCT, UNDP led Strategic Priority Area 4—focused on Governance, democratic institutions, the Rule of Law, Access to Justice, and Human Rights—strengthening coordination and ensuring the alignment of reforms with national priorities.

In parallel, the CO mobilized resources from partners such as Japan, and Switzerland, while reorienting ongoing donor-funded projects to reflect transition priorities. This combination of resource mobilization and portfolio adjustment enhanced agility and ensured that programming remained relevant without waiting for new funding cycles.

Flexible and Catalytic Funding

Access to early and flexible crisis response funding was one of the key enablers of the response. Funding Window Resources allowed the CO to front-load urgent activities in response to immediate requests from the Interim Government, particularly supporting electoral processes. This rapid engagement strengthened UNDP's credibility and built trust with national counterparts and these early investments acted as a catalyst for larger contributions. The funding from Crisis Bureau was therefore not only a short-term bridging mechanism but also a strategic instrument that enabled UNDP to leverage longer-term, higher-value commitments.

SURGE Deployments

This rapid deployment of a **multidisciplinary SURGE team (Governance Advisor-1, Youth and Civic Engagement Advisor-1, Security Sector Reform Advisor-1, Partnership Coordinator-1 and Security Advisor-1)** was a key enabler of the response. It was timely, relevant, and effective, providing the CO with an opportunity to recalibrate its governance programming and adopt a longer-term strategic vision during the political transition. The multidisciplinary team covering governance and peacebuilding, elections, security sector reform, youth and civic engagement, partnerships, and security provided targeted support. As most advisors were regionally based and familiar with the context, they were able to "hit the ground running" upon deployment.

Six-to-twelve- week deployments (with some longer assignments) provided continuity and allowed advisors to make meaningful contributions. Strong leadership within the Bangladesh CO and high levels of trust between SURGE advisors and national teams enabled quick decision-making and effective engagement in priority areas, including justice reform, police support, elections, and youth engagement.

The immediate deployment of a Governance Advisor, Security Sector Reform Advisor and Youth and Civic Engagement Advisor helped UNDP move quickly to position itself in governance, justice, electoral and police reform, and civic engagement, including early engagement with newly- established commissions.

The deployment of a Partnerships Coordinator provided critical support to the CO by helping resolve Financing Agreements delayed by HQ clearance procedures through close coordination with relevant HQ units. She also strengthened SDG Finance work by linking the CO with technical expertise in BERA and the Sustainable Finance Hub, supported youth crowdfunding and community product initiatives, enhanced visibility efforts, and contributed to reporting and internal coordination as needed.

Similarly, the deployment of a Security Advisor, alongside regular engagement with the Regional Security Focal Point, ensured that safety and security considerations were integrated into the response and helped maintain a secure operating environment for staff and operations.

Interviews indicated that SURGE deployments were effective largely because the Advisors were UNDP staff familiar with the region, institutional processes, and operating context. Existing relationships with the CO also helped accelerate the response and align support with government requests. In addition, geographic proximity, particularly for those deployed from the Bangkok Regional Hub—enabled greater flexibility to extend assignments, as needed.

While there was clear high-level guidance from the CO senior management for SURGE Advisors, preparing a brief Mission Plan and initial briefing within the first 48 hours could have further clarified priorities and expected responsibilities.

Analytical Support

The CO noted that Analysis and Options for response prepared by the CB and the Comparative Analyses and scenario papers produced by the SURGE team were most valuable once the crisis had evolved and conditions on the ground had become clearer. In the first two to three weeks, the operating environment remained highly fluid, requiring flexibility and rapid adaptation. During this initial phase, it was more useful for SURGE Advisors to provide agile political analysis, real-time assessments, and maintain close communication with national stakeholders.

As government priorities became better defined and feasible entry points for engagement emerged, the comparative analyses gained greater strategic relevance. The CO emphasized that the most impactful analyses were demand-driven—particularly those focused on elections, anti-corruption, and transitional justice—which directly informed the work of emerging reform commissions.

Special Measures— Programme and Operations

The CO used Special Measures selectively to support urgent procurements. However, their activation faced initial delays due to technical issues and a transition in the Operations Manager position. The CO also applied these measures cautiously, given existing compliance challenges in the CO's HR and procurement systems.

Of the 26 available Special Measures, the CO selected 10 and ultimately used five. The most significant was the exemption from the Social and Environmental Standards (SES) requirement for a project valued at approximately USD 6.9 million, which enabled the rapid initiation of activities. Other measures included increased RFQ thresholds, higher direct procurement limits, and adjustments to procurement delegation authorities. Together, these measures facilitated approximately USD 9 million in programme delivery.

The CO also noted challenges in tracking, monitoring, and reporting on the use of Special Measures, highlighting the need for clearer internal systems, stronger coordination between Programme and Operations Teams, and more targeted selection of measures by the CO based on its operational needs.

Early Recovery Hub

The Early Recovery Hub provided useful tools for the response, particularly in preparing statements on Early Recovery and related communication materials. However, most of the available resources are tailored to

disaster contexts. Greater attention is therefore needed to expand the guidance and tools to better reflect crisis situations related to political transitions.

Based on the experience in Bangladesh, the Early Recovery Hub could be further strengthened by including Terms of Reference for key areas such as youth and civic engagement and social inclusion. In addition, relevant guidance and documents produced by the GRP Hub should be consolidated and made easily accessible within the platform to support COs more effectively in similar contexts.

Flood response during Political Transition

The flood response unfolded in a context of multiple overlapping crises. Alongside the political transition and the protracted Rohingya situation in Cox's Bazar, severe floods affected approximately 18 million people, requiring the CO to operate across several crisis fronts simultaneously. Managing these pressures required careful prioritization and adaptability. The first CMST meeting on 9th September approved an allocation of USD 1 million from TRAC3 to support flood response efforts, enabling UNDP to respond rapidly to the needs of affected communities. The CO noted that different types of crises require differentiated support. For flood response, rapid access to flexible funding was critical. The availability of immediate response funding (TRAC3) allowed UNDP to contribute meaningfully to flood-affected areas while also strengthening relationships with government counterparts at both national and local levels.

Government counterparts and development partners recognized the flood response as timely, well-targeted, and complementary to the efforts of other actors. UNDP focused on shelter repair, livelihood assistance, and essential household items, addressing gaps not fully covered by humanitarian interventions. However, implementation also highlighted areas for improvement, including the need for stronger technical expertise in livelihood programming—particularly in socially conservative communities where women have limited experience with income-generating activities—and the importance of linking Shelter Assistance with financial mechanisms such as credit, social protection, or disaster risk financing to support full recovery.

Given limited resources, UNDP concentrated its efforts in one severely affected district. Rigorous beneficiary selection and verification process, damage assessments, and mobile-money transfers ensured transparency and efficiency, while the data generated informed broader recovery planning by partners. Lessons from the Response also helped shape larger investments, including a World Bank programme on Disaster Preparedness and Local Government Capacity, and underscored the importance of rapid mobilization and strong coordination across field teams, the Bangkok Regional Hub, and the Crisis Bureau.

3.4 Gender Equality and Youth and Civic Engagement

Gender, youth, and civic engagement were consistently acknowledged as important priorities throughout the response. At the same time, the fast-moving context and underlying political sensitivities shaped how systematically these areas could be addressed. Notably, where dedicated expertise and strong collaboration were in place—particularly within the governance portfolio and strategic communications—Gender perspectives were integrated. The Gender expert from the CO was integral part of all the discussions; the ideation, the design to ensure gender issues are integrated in governance work. While the application of Gender dimension was uneven across different areas of work; moving forward, a more systematic and coordinated approach can build on the existing good practices to strengthen gender integration.

On Youth and Civic Engagement, SURGE support played an important role in strengthening the CO's approach by improving coordination between teams. This enabled a more coherent, cross-portfolio effort and introduced key mechanisms—such as a unified Youth Strategy, a Youth Technical Working Group within the Country Office, and the Open and Inclusive Public Sphere framework—to more systematically integrate inclusion considerations across programming. The SURGE deployment also generated valuable evidence to inform inclusive policymaking, including a multi-university youth consultation and a joint UNDP–UNESCO media landscape assessment. While dedicated funding remained limited, existing resources were effectively

realigned to strengthen youth and civic engagement indicators and improve data disaggregation. At the same time, the engagement highlighted the importance of establishing clearer anchoring roles under senior management, rather than leaving them within a single program unit. This would help avoid silos and ensure that youth perspectives are consistently integrated from the outset of crisis responses.

3.5 Communications, Partnerships and Resource Mobilization

Funding from Crisis Bureau (USD 2M/Funding Window¹) played a catalytic role at an early stage of UNDP's support to the country's reform priorities, including assistance to the Election Commission in preparing for a credible, inclusive, and peaceful election. This early investment enabled UNDP to respond quickly, demonstrate results, and strengthen its position as one of the most credible and trusted Development Partners in Bangladesh's democratic governance and reform landscape.

This early positioning by CO senior management with Technical Advisors (including SURGE Advisors) helped mobilize substantial complementary financing. Under the BALLOT Project, the immediate funding of USD 2 million, helped to secure USD 11.6 million from multiple partners: Japan (USD 4.82 million), Sweden/Sida (USD 2.85 million), Canada (USD 1.5 million), Australia/DFAT (USD 1.30 million), the United Kingdom/FCDO (USD 0.68 million), and Norway (USD 0.50 million). Beyond BALLOT, the initial funding also helped catalyze additional financing for governance and justice reforms, including USD 1.34 million from Sweden/Sida, USD 1.8 million from SDC, USD 75,506 from FCDO, and USD 93,052 from DFAT and USD 100,000 from Norway. Together, these investments enabled UNDP to expand support to Electoral Commission, strengthen Governance and Justice Sector Reforms, promote inclusive participation and contribute meaningfully to efforts to ensure credible, inclusive, and peaceful elections in Bangladesh.

On Communications, the CO already has strong internal capacity. The additional contribution from SURGE was helpful in linking this capacity with regional and headquarters platforms, enabling more consistent coverage of crisis-related developments and follow-up support beyond the deployment period.

3.6 Effectiveness of the Operational Response

Duty of Care

Duty of care was a key operational priority during the crisis. Initial challenges with communication channels and staff safety highlighted important areas for strengthening preparedness, particularly in contexts involving internet shutdowns or movement restrictions. The experience from Bangladesh offers valuable insights for enhancing contingency planning, including the importance of ensuring satellite phones remain fully operational and that standard operating procedures for communication disruptions are regularly reviewed, tested, and updated.

In response, the CO implemented a range of measures to strengthen staff safety and ensure operational continuity. Starlink systems were installed in the CO, key BCP locations (including a dedicated vehicle) to maintain connectivity during potential internet shutdowns. Radio communications were also reinforced through the distribution of radios to national personnel and wardens, complemented by routine radio checks to ensure ongoing communication readiness.

Security arrangements were further enhanced through updates to the Business Continuity Plan (BCP), clearer delineation of staff roles and responsibilities, and the introduction of regular staff check-ins. Additional security personnel were recruited to support UNDSS and UNDP operations in Dhaka and Cox's Bazar. Collectively, these measures improved preparedness for future disruptions and strengthened staff confidence in institutional support systems.

¹ ProDev Global Flagship: Protecting Peace and Development Gains in Contexts Experiencing UN Mission Transition and/or Abrupt Transitions of Power

Human Resources

Human resources emerged as one of the most significant operational bottlenecks during the crisis response. The CO faced exceptionally high recruitment pressures, processing approximately 60–70 vacancies in 2024–2025 while programme demands were expanding rapidly. This placed considerable strain on the HR unit and slowed the pace at which additional operational capacity could be mobilized.

Recruitment challenges were further compounded by structural constraints in the national hiring environment, including limited candidate pools for specialized technical roles. While the SURGE roster provided some additional flexibility, onboarding timelines and recruitment processes continued to limit the speed.

4. KEY OBSERVATIONS, LESSONS LEARNED AND RECOMMENDATIONS

4.1 Key Observations and Lessons Learned

1. Coordination and timely support

The Bangladesh response demonstrated UNDP's strong institutional capacity, with effective coordination between RBAP, CB, and the CO. The BRH served as the main coordination channel and first responder. Coordination and support were centralized through a small core group in BRH, reducing duplication and managing information flow, which minimized fragmentation and overlapping support. Overall, the response was timely, pragmatic, and largely aligned with the CO's evolving needs, despite initial uncertainty about nature and scale of support.

2. Strong leadership and early strategic positioning

The UNDP CO senior management, led by the RR, provided strong and decisive leadership, ensuring a clear, organized, and strategic crisis response. With well-defined roles and high trust among teams and SURGE Advisors, the CO Senior Management made timely decisions and took calculated risks, positioning UNDP early in priority areas. Their coherent vision, preparedness, and effective coordination within the UN system enabled swift action, maintained strategic engagement, and balanced neutrality with meaningful involvement. This early leadership established UNDP's credibility and distinct niche compared to other UN agencies which were more cautious in their engagement.

3. Rapid deployment of SURGE Advisors

Rapid SURGE deployments and specialized advisory support, particularly in governance, elections, justice reform, partnerships, and civic engagement, had a significant strategic impact in the early days of the crisis. These advisors helped position UNDP credibly with the interim government and reform commissions. The key elements that enhanced effectiveness were the advisors' grounded knowledge of the context and dynamics, as well as their substantive experience working with national institutions. Six- to twelve-week deployments also helped ensure sustained support.

4. Flexible coordination enabling timely response

Small, focused coordination arrangements between the CO and BRH, supported by frequent weekly—and at times daily—calls between the RR, DRR, and BRH teams, along with flexible communication channels, enabled faster decision-making and effective alignment on priorities and support. In a political transition context with rapidly changing dynamics, flexible and nimble coordination mechanisms at regional level can respond quickly to CO needs and requests, in between the convening of the more formal structures like Crisis Board and the CMST. Lessons from Bangladesh suggest that future responses should prioritize a demand-driven approach tailored to CO priorities, to complement corporate coordination mechanisms.

5. Flexible funding

Access to flexible funding enabled the CO to respond in a timely manner to government requests, enhance credibility, and mobilize larger donor financing. Funding Window contributions were catalytic, enabling

UNDP to initiate critical electoral assistance that later attracted over USD 11 million, and triggered bilateral Agreements of more than USD 6 million to support governance work and nationwide Justice Reform consultations.

6. Gaps in crisis preparedness

The crisis highlighted opportunities to strengthen the CO's preparedness for responding to sudden service disruptions. It underscored the need for enhanced risk analysis, more robust Business Continuity Planning, and the development of Standard Operating Procedures for scenarios such as complete internet shutdowns. These experiences provide valuable guidance for improving preparedness frameworks, particularly in the context of Bangladesh's dynamic and sometimes unpredictable security environment following periods of unrest.

Second, the CO acknowledged the need for stronger Early Warning Systems, Scenario-based Planning, Political Economy Analysis, and Risk Analysis as well as Monitoring as essential components for improving preparedness.

Third, available resources and guidance through Early Recovery Hub were insufficient for responding to a political transition context, as most resources were designed primarily for natural disasters.

4.2 Recommendations

1. Country Office

- **Strengthen CO crisis preparedness:** COs operating in politically volatile environments should systematically integrate political risk monitoring and scenario-based contingency planning into their regular practices. This includes conducting regular Political Economy Analysis, organizing crisis simulations, and maintaining updated Business Continuity Plans that address potential disruptions such as internet shutdowns, mobility restrictions, or civil unrest.
- **Strengthen HR preparedness:** Consider pre-identifying critical positions and establish rapid recruitment pipelines or maintain pre-cleared candidate rosters (ICs) to enable timely deployment during crisis response. In addition, CO could leverage the Crisis Bureau's pre-classified crisis-related Terms of Reference, which can be activated under special measures to expedite recruitment processes. This would help fulfill the immediate gaps while longer-term recruitment processes are underway, ensuring continuity and responsiveness during crisis.
- **Enhance SURGE deployment effectiveness:** Develop and share CO's Mission Plan within the first 1–2 days of deployment, outlining roles, responsibilities, and expectations. Additionally, the CO should designate a dedicated focal point for programme coordination. This would streamline communication, improve alignment across teams, and clarify responsibilities, allowing SURGE Advisors to focus on delivering vital technical support rather than coordination functions.

2. Regional Bureau for Asia and the Pacific

- **Maintaining and Strengthening the Regional Hub as a First Responder:** The role of the Regional Hub as a first responder should be sustained and further strengthened, given its critical importance in providing timely and context specific support to COs during crises. This includes enhancing regional SURGE capacity in key areas such as Governance, Elections, Peacebuilding, and Political Economy to enable rapid deployment to countries undergoing political transitions, while ensuring that advisors who are likely to be deployed complete SURGE training in advance, either by participating in scheduled training opportunities or by undertaking the self-paced online course.
- **Enhance Regional knowledge-sharing:** Promote cross-country learning (example- exchange between Nepal and Bangladesh) and help COs anticipate challenges and opportunities during periods of political transition.

3. Crisis Bureau

- **Strengthening CO capacity to effectively respond to conflict and/or political transition crises**
 - **In coordination with RBAP**, provide support and guidance to the COs in key areas such as risk monitoring, scenario planning, and political economy analysis to enable more timely and informed responses.
 - **Adapt crisis tools for political transition contexts:** Expand crisis response resources and early recovery hub tools to better reflect the needs of political transition and conflict settings, recognizing that the ERH currently focuses primarily on disaster-related crisis response. This includes developing standard Terms of Reference for priority areas such as youth and civic engagement, as well as social cohesion. Consolidating relevant guidance and resources within the GRP Hub would improve accessibility and support more effective CO responses.
 - **Continue providing orientation on Special Measures:** Continue organizing dedicated sessions for COs on Special Measures, ensuring they can clearly understand and apply the appropriate measures based on their operating context.
 - **Strengthen conflict-sensitive programming skills:** Consider organizing refresher training for SURGE Advisors on conflict-sensitive programming to enhance effectiveness, particularly in political transition environments.
 - **Promote and facilitate inter-regional peer learning exchanges** by creating opportunities for teams across regions to share experiences, lessons learned, and good practices. This will strengthen cross-regional collaboration and support more effective crisis response.
 - **Encourage/promote demand-driven coordination mechanism:** Promote demand-driven coordination mechanisms. The Bangladesh response showed that in rapidly evolving contexts, flexible and demand-driven coordination, supported by frequent interactions and swift decision-making, is more effective than formal mechanisms, which can be slower and less practical in dynamic situations.

ANNEXES

Annex 1: List of people interviewed

S.N	Name	Title	Unit	Email
1	Stefan Liller	Resident Representative	CO	stefan.liller@undp.org
2	Sonali Dayaratne	Deputy Resident Representative	CO	sonali.dayaratne@undp.org
3	Anowarul Haq	Asst. Resident Representative Democratic Governance	CO	anowarul.haq@undp.org
4	Sarder M Asaduzzaman	Asst. Resident Representative Inclusive Growth	CO	sarder.asaduzzaman@undp.org
5	Romana Schweiger	Sr. Advisor, RoL and Human Rights	CO	romana.schweiger@undp.org
6	Mariyam Nazra	Operations Manager	CO	mariyam.nazra@undp.org
7	Owais Parray	Country Economic Advisor	CO	owais.parray@undp.org
8	Apurba Swatee Mahboob	Project Analyst	CO	apurba.mahboob@undp.org
9	Gerd Trogemann	Manager, Bangkok Regional Hub	RBAP/BRH	gerd.trogemann@undp.org
10	Paola Piccione	Country Program Specialist	RBAP/BRH	paola.piccione@undp.org
11	Jakob Schemel	Special Asst. to the Regional Director	RBAP/HQ	jakob.schemel@undp.org
12	Rebecca Reynolds	Team Leader, C3RT-Asia Pacific Region	CB/BRH	rebecca.reynolds@undp.org
13	Navindra Persaud	Program Specialist	CB/HQ	navindra.persaud@undp.org
14	Kiye Mwakawago	Program Specialist	CB/HQ	kiye.mwakawago@undp.org
15	Simone Boneschi (SURGE)	Program Specialist, Human Rights and RoL	CB/BRH	simone.boneschi@undp.org
16	Dilrukshi Fonseka (SURGE)	PDA (currently DRR-Myanmar)	CB/BRH	dilrukshi.fonseka@undp.org
17	Beniam Gebrezghi (SURGE)	Program Specialist, Civil Society and Youth	BPPS/BRH	beniam.gebrezghi@undp.org
18	Lucy Wanjiru (SURGE)	Private Sector Partnership and Due Diligence Specialist	BERA/HQ	lucy.wanjiru@undp.org
19	Gary Stephen Springer (SURGE)	Security Specialist	BMS/BRH	gary.stephen.springer@undp.org

Annex 2: Concept note AAR

Concept Note: After Action Review (AAR) – UNDP Bangladesh Crisis Response

1. Purpose

- The After-Action Review aims to assess and reflect on UNDP's crisis response (political-L3 as well as response to floods) in Bangladesh, with a focus on identifying lessons learned to improve future readiness and response capacities, in particular for political transitions. The exercise will provide an opportunity for the CO, with support from relevant regional and HQ teams, to review the clarity and timeliness of decision-making, the effectiveness of programmatic and operational responses, and the use of corporate mechanisms and resources.

Specifically, the AAR will focus on:

- The clarity and timeliness of decision-making processes during the crisis response;
- The timeliness and effectiveness of the programmatic response, including access to and use of corporate funding instruments and if/how they have been strategically used to leverage additional development resources;
- Operational performance, including Special Measures, staffing, SURGE deployment, procurement, logistics, and overall operational agility.

2. Methodology

The AAR will be conducted internally and designed as a light, lessons learned exercise. It will include the following components:

- Desk Review of key documents
- Interviews with selected staff from the CO, RBAP, Crisis Bureau and BPPS, BERA BMS- where necessary, including SURGE personnel, to gather perspectives on what worked well and what could be improved.
- Synthesis of Lessons into a short report with practical recommendations for institutional learning

3. Expected Outcome

A lessons learned report highlighting key enablers and bottlenecks during the crisis response; good practices in coordination, decision-making, and operations, specific recommendations to improve timeliness and effectiveness of future responses.

4. Timeline: December 2025 to February 2026 (10 weeks)

S.N	Description	Timeline
1.	Initial meeting with RBAP and CO	December
2.	Desk Review	December
3.	Interviews	January and February
4.	Draft and finalize report	March

5. Guiding questions

A. Coordination and Decision-Making

- Were decision-making roles and responsibilities clearly defined at the onset of the crisis?
- How timely and appropriate were the decisions made by the Country Office leadership/ CB/RBAP/ Crisis Board?
- How effective was internal coordination between CO, RBAP, Crisis Bureau, and central Bureaus? What supported or hindered fast and coordinated decision making across CO, BRH and HQ?
- Were there any delays or ambiguities in approvals or guidance that impacted implementation?
- How did UNDP coordinate with other UN agencies, government counterparts, and partners during the response?

B. Programmatic Response and Use of Corporate Mechanisms

1. How timely and relevant was the programmatic response to the needs on the ground?
2. To what extent were corporate tools and funding (e.g., TRAC 3, SURGE deployments) accessed and used effectively?
3. How well did the response incorporate cross-cutting priorities such as gender equality and social inclusion?
4. To what extent were the programmatic offer and corporate funding strategically used to leverage additional development resources? Were there any innovations or adaptive programming approaches used that proved effective?
5. Was communications capacity sufficient to match the scale and complexity of the crisis? How did the CO use communications to support the government, build partnerships, and mobilize resources in a complex environment?

C. Operational Performance

1. Was the CO operationally agile in responding to emerging needs (e.g., safety and security, logistics, staffing)?
1. What operational challenges (e.g., safety and security of staff, office access) emerged and how were they addressed?
2. Did existing SOPs and workflows facilitate or hinder a timely response?
3. How effective was the activation and use of the Operational Special Measures?

D. Institutional Learning and Readiness

1. What were the key enablers that contributed to a successful response, looking at mechanisms for information sharing, coordination, defining UNDP's offer and resource mobilization strategy?
2. What were the main bottlenecks that limited UNDP's ability to respond more quickly or effectively?
3. Were there examples of effective collaboration that can be replicated in future responses?
4. What processes or capacities need to be improved for future crisis readiness in Bangladesh?
5. What recommendations do you have for future responses?